
APPS



Hank Green's Focus Friend app is climbing the App Store charts — and it's extremely cute

You must stay focused. You cannot open TikTok, or Instagram, or whatever little phone games you like to play. If you fail, you will make an anthropomorphic bean very sad, because its knitting project depends on your ability to stay focused.

This is the premise of [Focus Friend](#), a productivity app created by [Honey B Games](#) and [Hank Green](#), the longtime online creator/entrepreneur/educator/[sock salesman](#). Though the app was soft launched last month, Focus Friend is only now gaining momentum on the App Store charts — likely because Green and his brother, author John Green, are [posting about it more](#) — reaching No. 4 among all free apps and No. 2 among productivity apps.



Watch now

@hankgreen1 ✓

Your Deserve a Focus Friend
original sound - Hank Green

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Focus Friend, which is available on [iOS](#) and [Android](#), has the bones of a typical productivity app. It invites you to set a timer on your phone, which will temporarily prevent you from opening certain apps (on iOS, the “Deep Focus Mode” setting connects to your own screen time settings, where you can designate which apps to block).

But what makes Focus Friend different is that it assigns you a new friend — a little bean — which you can give a cute name, like Garbanzo, or Susan Bean Anthony, or Eda (it’s short for Edamame).

Your bean needs help focusing on its knitting. And it can only focus if you refrain from opening the apps that distract you from your work. If you successfully complete your focus session, your bean will give you in-game points (socks), which you can use to buy decorations for its room — because the only thing more motivating than helping a bean knit is to buy it a cute poster for its wall.

Focus Friend has a lot in common with [Finch](#), a popular self-care app that incentivizes users to maintain healthy habits by giving them a virtual bird companion. Your bird grows when you complete certain tasks that you set for yourself, like drinking water, brushing your teeth, or cleaning your room. Like the Tamagotchis of yore, these apps exploit our desire to protect a cute bundle of pixels by doing stuff that’s good for us.

Focus Friend is functional as a free app, but you can pay to give your bean different skins — you can make your bean look like a cat (a “Kitt-ney Bean”) or a jelly bean, for example. There’s also a subscription that allows your bean to knit scarves, which can be exchanged for premium decorations. Green [posted](#) on Bluesky that Focus Friend is “very much trying to be an ad-free experience because the mobile ad ecosystem kinda blows.” But the app still has to make money to compensate the employees who brought our beans to life.



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Amanda Silberling

Senior Writer |

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also written for...

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X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

Sarah Perez — 1:49 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

Elon Musk's X is struggling on Android devices in terms of new installs, even while App Store downloads grow, according to new data from app intelligence provider Appfigures. In July 2025, X downloads on Google Play saw a significant decline, as new installs dropped by 44% year-over-year worldwide, even as iOS downloads grew by 15%.

This steep drop in installs is pulling down X's overall average, leading to a 26% decrease in total mobile downloads year-over-year as of July. That's still slightly better than the month prior, when total downloads had fallen by 35%, thanks to another sharp drop in Android downloads, which were then down by nearly half (49%) year-over-year.

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play



IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm didn't speculate on what's causing the decline on Android devices beyond suggesting that the X app on Android is known to be a sore spot for the company. Recently hired [X head of product Nikita Bier](#), known for growth hacking teen social apps like [Gas](#) and [TBH](#) (then [selling them](#)), has hinted that X is

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looking to address issues on Android, where its app is [notoriously buggy](#) and [often crashes](#).

In a post on the platform, Bier [announced](#) that X was hiring for its “Android Dream Team” to work on rebuilding the X Android app. He also recently posted that X’s iOS app [had just seen a record week in terms of installs](#), perhaps hoping to draw attention away from the large Android slump.

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month with Year-Over-Year Growth

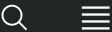
Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play

Month	App Store	YoY	Google Play	YoY	Unified	YoY
Jan-24	2,963,000	-	6,303,000	-	9,266,000	-
Feb-24	3,623,000	-	6,352,000	-	9,975,000	-

Latest
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Venture
Apple

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AI
Apps

Events
Podcasts
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Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.

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Spotify's latest feature lets you add your own

transitions to playlists

Sarah Perez — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Spotify is **introducing** a new feature that allows subscribers to create more professional, personalized playlists. On Tuesday, the company launched a custom transitions feature that lets you either automatically add transitions between a playlist's tracks or customize your own using preset options like fade, rise, or blend, along with other options.

To use the feature, open any playlist and select "Mix" from the toolbar to begin editing. While customizing the track with different transition styles, you can also adjust settings for things like the volume, EQ, and effects, and use the waveform and beat data to find the best spot in each track to begin the transition.

IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

Spotify notes that it will automatically display the key and the beats per minute for each track, to make it easier for novice audio mixers to get started.

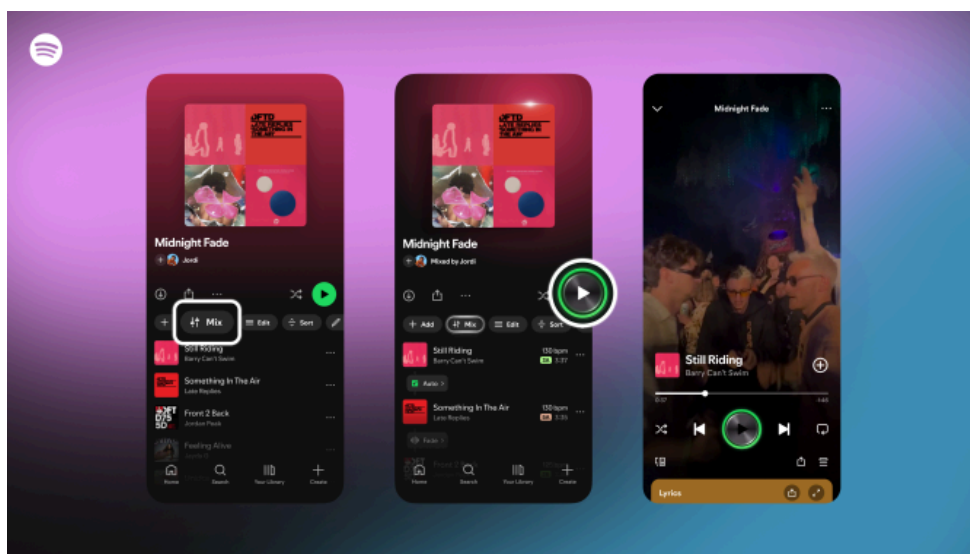


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

The new options are designed to appeal to playlist experts and other music fans, who have collectively created nearly 9 billion playlists on Spotify's platform to date.



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TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

Aisha Malik - 1 hour ago

The rollout complements other updates Spotify has launched over the past year that give users more control over their listening experience, the company says, like the tools to [add, sort, and edit playlists](#), [customize the genre of the Discover Weekly](#) playlist, [snooze tracks](#), [make voice requests to the AI DJ](#), and more. It also allows Spotify to compete with Apple Music’s [upcoming](#) AutoMix feature, which is currently live in the iOS 26 developer beta, and claims to let you mix “like a DJ.”

Premium subscribers with access to the transitions feature will also be able to save and share the playlist with other friends on social media or even invite other subscribers to collaborate on a mixed playlist.

The mix can be toggled on and off at any time by pressing the “mix” option, allowing you to turn your playlist back to the more traditional kind when the party or gym workout (or wherever else you’re streaming the mix) has ended.

APPS



Spotify’s latest feature lets you add your own transitions to playlists

Sarah Perez - 4 hours ago

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OpenAI launches a sub-\$5 ChatGPT plan in India

Ivan Mehta - 10 hours ago



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The company recommends that mixing works best with music that’s already been produced for seamless transitions, like house and techno, which tend to blend more easily.

Like other playlists, the mixes can be further [customized using your own cover art](#) along with newly added stickers and labels made just for mixed playlists.

Custom transitions in playlists are available starting today for the majority of eligible Premium users worldwide. (The company says some markets in the APAC region will still need to wait for the addition.) The feature is rolling out gradually to users who have updated their Spotify app for iOS or Android.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Media & Entertainment](#) [Music](#) [Spotify](#) [streaming](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [Medium](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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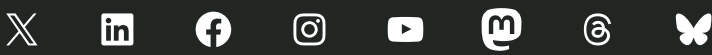
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